

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Sources of Ancient Indian History - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Sources of Ancient Indian History	
01 SOURCE CRITICISM: AUTHENTICITY, MEANING AND CORROBORATION Technically, Source Criticism Authority, Meaning and	02 ARCHAEOLOGY & ARTIFACT: INDUSTRY, ASSEMBLAGE AND CULTURE — [CORE PRELIMS Archaeology is the only discipline source for prehistory
03 ARCHAEOLOGY IN SURVEY, STRATIGRAPHY AND EXCAVATION STRATEGY — [CORE PRELIMS + Archaeology and related strategies are complementary, not rival	04 SCIENTIFIC DATING AND ARCHAOMETRY: PRECISION WITH ERROR BARS Technically, Scientific Dating and Archaeometry Precision With Error
05 BIOARCHAEOLOGY: ENVIRONMENT AND ETHNOARCHAEOLOGY Bioarchaeology suggests possible functions and production	06 EPIGRAPHY & INSCRIPTIONS, SCRIPTS AND DECIPHERMENT — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE An inscription is writing engraved or stone, metal, wood, clay, brick
07 EPIGRAPHY IN TYPES, DATING, USES AND BIASES — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS] Technically, Epigraphy & Types, Dating, Uses and Biases — Core	08 NUMISMATICS & READING A COIN AS OBJECT, TEXT AND INSTRUMENT — [CORE PRELIMS + Coins are valuable because their composition and date can be
09 NUMISMATICS IN HISTORICAL USES AND INTERPRETATION LIMITS — [CORE PRELIMS + Technically, Numismatics & Historical Uses and Interpretation Limits	10 MANUSCRIPTS: ORAL TRANSMISSION AND CRITICAL EDITIONS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE Manuscript history is part of textual history, preservation and
11 BRAHMINICAL LITERARY SOURCES: VEDAS, EPICS, PURANAS AND SHASTRAS — [CORE But Archaeology can show uniform and material pattern of sources	12 BUDDHIST, JAINA AND SANGAM SOURCES — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS] The legend of these sources is not accepted broadly, some historians
13 FOREIGN ACCOUNTS: GREEK, ROMAN, CHINESE AND ARAB WITNESSES — [CORE PRELIMS + Alexander's Indian campaign is reconstructed primarily through	14 LINGUISTIC EVIDENCE, ORAL TRADITIONS AND VILLAGE STUDY Technically, Linguistic Evidence, Oral Traditions and Village Study is
15 MONUMENTS, MATERIAL CULTURE AND VISUAL SOURCES Visual evidence has formal content and material content, both must	16 CHRONOLOGY: RELATIVE, ABSOLUTE AND TEXTUAL TIME — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE Build chronology by convergence sequence + absolute range +
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Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Sources of Ancient Indian History - Learner-v2 Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Diagnostic and repair protocol - [CORE PRELIMS]

- Attempt before reading the explanation.
- Classify each error as chronology, evidence, identity, causation, region or overclaim.
- Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed.

Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed., repeated eight times.

MCQ 1

A source is best described as a refracted image when:

- A. Translation removes bias
- B. It represents society through genre, purpose and viewpoint
- C. Only inscriptions count as evidence
- D. It is necessarily false

Answer: B. Sources mediate the past; refracted does not mean useless.

MCQ 2

A critical edition primarily:

- A. Selects the newest manuscript
- B. Compares manuscript witnesses and records variants
- C. Translates a text into English
- D. Treats every reading as equally original

Answer: B. Its core task is comparative textual criticism with a critical apparatus.

MCQ 3

Which feature most increases an artefact's historical value?

- A. Secure layer, findspot and association
- B. A royal symbol
- C. Museum display
- D. Metallic beauty

Answer: A. Context converts an object into evidence.

MCQ 4

Which statement on excavation is correct?

- A. Horizontal excavation always gives chronology
- B. Vertical excavation always gives settlement plan
- C. Remote sensing fixes exact dates
- D. Vertical and horizontal strategies answer different questions

Answer: D. Vertical is sequence-heavy; horizontal is plan-heavy.

MCQ 5

An assemblage is:

- A. A single diagnostic artefact
- B. Only a pottery collection

- C. All associated industries and remains at a site
- D. A dynastic coin series

Answer: C. Assemblage is the combined material set in context.

MCQ 6

Which is a valid radiocarbon caution?

- A. It yields an error range and needs calibration/context
- B. It dates stone directly
- C. It identifies language
- D. It is unaffected by contamination

Answer: A. C-14 dates organic samples probabilistically.

MCQ 7

In radiocarbon reporting, BP conventionally uses:

- A. 1950 as baseline
- B. The date of excavation
- C. 1 CE
- D. The start of the Shaka era

Answer: A. BP is Before Present with 1950 as the baseline.

MCQ 8

Archaeometry is best defined as:

- A. A synonym for archaeology
- B. Study of royal inscriptions only
- C. Scientific measurement and analysis of ancient materials
- D. A fixed hierarchy of sources

Answer: C. It includes chemical, physical and other measurement techniques.

MCQ 9

Epigraphy includes:

- A. Decipherment and analysis of inscriptions, including palaeography
- B. Only translation of Sanskrit
- C. Coin-weight measurement
- D. Only copper-plate study

Answer: A. Palaeography is a component of epigraphic analysis.

MCQ 10

Kharoshthi is most safely associated with:

- A. Right-to-left writing and the north-west
- B. Left-to-right writing across all India
- C. Harappan decipherment
- D. South Indian temple walls only

Answer: A. Its core area was Gandhara/north-west and it ran right to left.

MCQ 11

Brahmi's long-term significance is that it:

- A. Was identical to Harappan
- B. Was confined to Ashoka
- C. Was always written right to left

- D. Became parent to many South Asian scripts

Answer: D. Its later regional developments shaped many scripts.

MCQ 12

An undated inscription may be approximately dated through:

- A. Royal praise alone
- B. Its present museum
- C. Palaeography, language, formula and context
- D. Modern translation

Answer: C. Multiple relative indicators are combined.

MCQ 13

Which is an official inscriptional record?

- A. A private guild donation
- B. An Ashokan edict
- C. A pilgrim's graffiti
- D. An anonymous hero stone

Answer: B. The edict is issued on royal authority.

MCQ 14

The main caution with a prashasti is:

- A. It contains no historical material
- B. It is panegyric and may exaggerate or omit
- C. It cannot be dated
- D. It is always private

Answer: B. Praise rhetoric must be separated from usable detail.

MCQ 15

Metrology in numismatics studies:

- A. Scripts
- B. Only mint towns
- C. Religious symbols
- D. Weights and standards

Answer: D. Metrology is measurement and arrangement by weight.

MCQ 16

Why can coin distribution exceed political territory?

- A. Coins cannot move
- B. Precious value, trade and long circulation cross borders
- C. Every coin is copied
- D. All hoards are modern

Answer: B. Circulation is not identical to sovereignty.

MCQ 17

A coin hoard is especially useful because:

- A. It is a complete sample of all coins
- B. It always proves invasion
- C. Its composition can illuminate circulation and burial chronology
- D. It has no selection bias

Answer: C. Hoard context and the latest coin can be chronological clues.

MCQ 18

Counter-striking most securely establishes that:

- A. Both rulers were identical
- B. The coin never circulated
- C. The undertype is earlier than or contemporary with the overtype
- D. The overtype is foreign

Answer: C. Overstrike sequence creates relative chronology.

MCQ 19

The chief historical lesson of palm-leaf manuscript copying is:

- A. Transmission preserves texts while creating variants
- B. Copies are all identical
- C. Composition begins with printing
- D. Material form is irrelevant

Answer: A. Scribal survival and textual variation are inseparable.

MCQ 20

Why is religious/secular classification hazardous for ancient Indian texts?

- A. All texts are ritual manuals
- B. All texts are secular
- C. Dharma means only religion
- D. Ancient categories interweave domains separated by modern usage

Answer: D. Modern boundaries should not be imposed mechanically.

MCQ 21

The strongest use of Vedic texts is to:

- A. Treat every hymn as a dated event report
- B. Reconstruct layered ritual, social and linguistic worlds critically
- C. Identify one archaeological culture exactly
- D. Ignore archaeology

Answer: B. Their value is substantial but genre/layer dependent.

MCQ 22

Dharmashastra is primarily:

- A. Normative-prescriptive literature requiring practice checks
- B. A statistical census
- C. A foreign account
- D. A coin catalogue

Answer: A. It states ideals and rules from a located viewpoint.

MCQ 23

Buddhist and Jaina texts are best treated as:

- A. Unbiased replacements for Brahmanical texts
- B. Pure fiction
- C. Alternative sectarian windows with their own layers
- D. Archaeological reports

Answer: C. They diversify but do not neutralize perspective.

MCQ 24

Sangam poems become strongest historical evidence when:

- A. Separated from Tamil archaeology
- B. Dated only by legend
- C. Taken literally as court minutes
- D. Correlated with inscriptions, coins, ports and material culture

Answer: D. Convergence strengthens regional reconstruction.

MCQ 25

Which is the best first test of a traveller's account?

- A. Whether the traveller praises India
- B. Route, purpose, language and audience
- C. Whether it is old
- D. Whether it mentions a king

Answer: B. Observer filters determine what could be seen and said.

MCQ 26

Linguistic evidence should not be equated mechanically with:

- A. Contact
- B. Race or fixed ethnicity
- C. Loanwords
- D. Language change

Answer: B. Language spread and biological identity are distinct problems.

MCQ 27

A visual source should be read through:

- A. Material, phase, patronage, iconography and context
- B. Aesthetic beauty alone
- C. Dynasty name alone
- D. Modern popularity

Answer: A. Visual evidence is both material and representational.

MCQ 28

Which statement best describes text-archaeology relation?

- A. Archaeology always proves texts
- B. Texts always date artefacts
- C. They must say identical things
- D. They answer different questions and should be correlated at matching scale

Answer: D. Their evidence types are qualitatively different.

MCQ 29

Absence of evidence is strongest when:

- A. The object was looted
- B. The source is silent by genre
- C. The expected trace should preserve and survey coverage is strong
- D. No excavation was conducted

Answer: C. Expected visibility and search intensity matter.

MCQ 30

Why must excavation results be published?

- A. Publication decorates the find
- B. Only museums can read reports
- C. Publication fixes contamination
- D. Excavation is destructive and others need records to verify it

Answer: D. The original context cannot be re-excavated.

MCQ 31

The Harappan script currently provides:

- A. A complete king list
- B. A translated law code
- C. Proof of Brahmi ancestry
- D. Undeciphered inscribed material, not readable narrative

Answer: D. It is evidence of signs/writing practice without secure decipherment.

MCQ 32

The strongest chronological reconstruction combines:

- A. Only inscriptions
- B. Only carbon dates
- C. Relative sequence, scientific ranges, epigraphic anchors and textual layers
- D. Only textual tradition

Answer: C. Independent chronological methods should converge.

Correct options rotate strictly D -> B -> A -> C, repeated twice.

Remedial MCQ 33

An unprovenanced sculpture should be treated as:

- A. A damaged historical source whose context is largely lost
- B. More reliable than excavation
- C. Proof of a dynasty
- D. Self-dating

Answer: A. Aesthetic survival does not restore find context.

Remedial MCQ 34

PGW at sites named in the Mahabharata establishes:

- A. The war exactly as narrated
- B. Occupation/material culture in a relevant broad period, not named events
- C. A single political empire
- D. The authorship of the epic

Answer: B. Archaeology addresses occupation patterns, not epic characters directly.

Remedial MCQ 35

A royal inscription is weakest for:

- A. A representative common people's viewpoint
- B. Royal ideology
- C. Genealogy claims
- D. Language history

Answer: A. Its issuer and purpose privilege elite claims.

Remedial MCQ 36

Coins minted by a ruler:

- A. Map exact borders
- B. Always circulate only one year
- C. Never leave the kingdom
- D. May circulate beyond borders and after the dynasty

Answer: D. Trade, value and reuse extend circulation.

Remedial MCQ 37

The best wording for a C-14 result is:

- A. An exact date without error
- B. Proof of ethnicity
- C. A calibrated probability range with stated error and sample context
- D. A script date

Answer: C. Scientific dates remain ranges tied to samples.

Remedial MCQ 38

A single aDNA sample can safely establish:

- A. The language of a civilization
- B. The political boundary
- C. The caste system
- D. Biological information about the sampled individual, within limits

Answer: D. Population claims require broader sampling and cannot directly identify social categories.

Remedial MCQ 39

A 12th-century manuscript of an epic necessarily dates:

- A. The epic event
- B. The first oral composition
- C. That manuscript witness, not the whole composition
- D. All interpolations

Answer: C. Composition and copy dates differ.

Remedial MCQ 40

The proper source hierarchy is:

- A. Texts above all
- B. Science above all
- C. Inscriptions above all
- D. Question-specific weighting with transparent limits

Answer: D. No fixed hierarchy works for every historical problem.

Audit Set: Eight High-Yield Elimination Drills - [CORE PRELIMS]

The original 40-question set already spans every core source class and includes remediation. These eight non-duplicative drills preserve the most useful elimination rules, continuing the strict A → A → B → D sequence from MCQ 40.

Audit MCQ 41

Which statement is the soundest source-critical reading?

- A. Provenience is the precise recorded find location and context of an item.
- B. It makes the source a complete and universal record without further checking.
- C. It removes the need to establish context, date and purpose.
- D. It proves all other source families irrelevant.

Answer: A. Provenience is the precise recorded find location and context of an item. Reject options that turn a bounded source yield into a universal conclusion.

Audit MCQ 42

Which statement is the soundest source-critical reading?

- A. It proves all other source families irrelevant.
- B. A later manuscript is a transmission witness whose copy date and textual layer must be separated.
- C. It makes the source a complete and universal record without further checking.
- D. It removes the need to establish context, date and purpose.

Answer: B. A later manuscript is a transmission witness whose copy date and textual layer must be separated. Reject options that turn a bounded source yield into a universal conclusion.

Audit MCQ 43

Which statement is the soundest source-critical reading?

- A. It makes the source a complete and universal record without further checking.
- B. It proves all other source families irrelevant.
- C. It removes the need to establish context, date and purpose.
- D. A royal eulogy is a public claim whose praise must be distinguished from usable detail.

Answer: D. A royal eulogy is a public claim whose praise must be distinguished from usable detail. Reject options that turn a bounded source yield into a universal conclusion.

Audit MCQ 44

Which statement is the soundest source-critical reading?

- A. It makes the source a complete and universal record without further checking.
- B. A coin found far from its issuer shows movement requiring contextual interpretation.
- C. It removes the need to establish context, date and purpose.
- D. It proves all other source families irrelevant.

Answer: B. A coin found far from its issuer shows movement requiring contextual interpretation. Reject options that turn a bounded source yield into a universal conclusion.

Audit MCQ 45

Which statement is the soundest source-critical reading?

- A. A scientific date requires sample, association, range and contextual evidence.
- B. It makes the source a complete and universal record without further checking.
- C. It removes the need to establish context, date and purpose.
- D. It proves all other source families irrelevant.

Answer: A. A scientific date requires sample, association, range and contextual evidence. Reject options that turn a bounded source yield into a universal conclusion.

Audit MCQ 46

Which statement is the soundest source-critical reading?

- A. It proves all other source families irrelevant.
- B. It makes the source a complete and universal record without further checking.
- C. A traveller account requires route, language access, informants, audience and selection checks.
- D. It removes the need to establish context, date and purpose.

Answer: C. A traveller account requires route, language access, informants, audience and selection checks. Reject options that turn a bounded source yield into a universal conclusion.

Audit MCQ 47

Which statement is the soundest source-critical reading?

- A. It removes the need to establish context, date and purpose.
- B. Not attested in one royal text is not the same as non-existence.
- C. It proves all other source families irrelevant.
- D. It makes the source a complete and universal record without further checking.

Answer: B. Not attested in one royal text is not the same as non-existence. Reject options that turn a bounded source yield into a universal conclusion.

Audit MCQ 48

Which statement is the soundest source-critical reading?

- A. It makes the source a complete and universal record without further checking.
- B. It removes the need to establish context, date and purpose.
- C. A final verdict should link source fitness, convergence and acknowledged gaps.
- D. It proves all other source families irrelevant.

Answer: C. A final verdict should link source fitness, convergence and acknowledged gaps. Reject options that turn a bounded source yield into a universal conclusion.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verification and answer protocol - [CORE MAINS]

- Preserve official-key status exactly; inferred keys remain prominently labelled.
- Every Mains answer must use claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> verdict.
- Every solved Mains answer retains its specific Why this earns marks note.

PYQ 1. 2018 GS-I Mains Q2 - Chinese and Arab Travellers

Status: Official printed question verified from the local UPSC paper.

Question: Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the reconstruction of the history of India. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution: Chinese and Arab accounts are indispensable but selective external witnesses. **Faxian's early-fifth-century itinerary and Xuanzang's seventh-century travels**, including his long engagement with Nalanda and Buddhist centres, reconstruct pilgrimage routes, monasteries, learning and regional conditions; they prove institutional geography, but a pilgrim's route magnifies Buddhism and leaves much of society unseen. **Sulaiman and al-Masudi's ninth-tenth-century notices** illuminate Indian Ocean commerce and the external reputation of Indian polities; they establish connectivity, although merchant information and hearsay can blur direct observation. **Al-Biruni's Tahqiq-i-Hind*** uses Sanskrit learning to discuss scripts, sciences, geography, religion and social

classification; it reveals intellectual worlds comparatively, but its north-western setting and elite textual access narrow its social range. Correlation with Nalanda's archaeology, inscriptions, coins, ports and Indian texts converts these observations into firmer history. Thus travellers supply datable comparison and otherwise omitted detail, but remain corroborative witnesses rather than neutral all-India surveys.

Why this earns marks: It answers **assess**, develops three named evidence clusters, states what each reconstructs and limits, and ends with a comparative corroboration-based verdict suited to 10 marks.

Examiner-grade requirement: Must define their value comparatively, identify observer filters, use co-relation and end with a graded verdict.

PYQ 2. 2020 GS-I Mains Q1 - Rock-Cut Architecture as Source

Status: Official printed question verified from the local UPSC paper.

Question: The rock-cut architecture represents one of the most important sources of our knowledge of early Indian art and history. Discuss. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution: Rock-cut monuments are built archives of technique, patronage and religious institutions. **Bhaja's chaitya hall (c. 100-70 BCE)** retains wooden ceiling ribs and slightly leaning stone pillars; it proves how timber forms were translated into durable rock, though formal resemblance supplies only relative dating. **The Nashik and Karle cave inscriptions of Ushavadata, Nahapana's son-in-law**, connect excavation and endowment with Kshatrapa authority, donors and western-Deccan routes; they reveal patronage networks, but donative claims do not represent the whole economy. **Ajanta chaityas 9 and 10**, with early murals of Jataka and worship scenes, preserve painting, ritual movement and courtly imagery otherwise easily lost; later additions and repainting require phase separation. Chaitya-vihara plans also recover monastic organization along commercial-pilgrimage corridors. Yet caves privilege durable religious and elite activity over ordinary housing. Rock-cut architecture is therefore a major source when style is anchored by inscriptions, construction phases, landscape and portable archaeology.

Why this earns marks: It discusses three named sites or inscriptional clusters, links each to a historical inference and a source limit, and gives a qualified 10-mark verdict rather than merely praising monuments.

Examiner-grade requirement: A top answer treats architecture as evidence, names what it reveals, and states phase/patronage/preservation limits.

PYQ 3. 2023 Prelims Q46 - Literary Work and Author

Status: Official question verified; official 2023 key unavailable locally. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

Question: Pairs: (1) Devichandragupta-Bilhana, (2) Hammira-Mahakavya-Nayachandra Suri, (3) Milinda-panha-Nagarjuna, (4) Nitivakyamrita-Somadeva Suri. How many are correctly matched?

Option
A. Only one
B. Only two
C. Only three
D. All four

Answer: B

Model solution: Pair 1 is wrong: Devichandraguptam is associated with Vishakhadatta, not Bilhana. Pair 2 is correct. Pair 3 is wrong: Milinda-panha is a dialogue centered on Nagasena, not a work authored by Nagarjuna. Pair 4 is correct. Hence two pairs are correct. Confidence: high.

Examiner-grade requirement: The question tests exact attribution and the danger of confusing similar names within literary traditions.

PYQ 4. 2023 Prelims Q81 - Colonial Archaeologists

Status: Official question verified; official 2023 key unavailable locally. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

Question: Alexander Rea, A. H. Longhurst, Robert Sewell, James Burgess and Walter Elliot were associated with what?

Option
A. Archaeological excavations
B. Establishment of English Press in Colonial India
C. Establishment of churches in princely states
D. Construction of railways in Colonial India

Answer: A

Model solution: They are associated with archaeological and antiquarian work in colonial India. The distractors belong to unrelated institutional histories. Confidence: high.

Examiner-grade requirement: Build an institutional map of archaeology, epigraphy and museums, not only a list of ancient sites.

PYQ 5. 2024 Prelims Q55 - Archaeological Site Matching

Status: Official Set-A question and official Set-A key verified locally.

Question: Rows: Chandraketugarh-Odisha-Trading port town; Inamgaon-Maharashtra-Chalcolithic site; Mangadu-Kerala-Megalithic site; Salihundam-Andhra Pradesh-Rock-cut cave shrines. Which rows are correctly matched?

Option
A. 1 and 2
B. 2 and 3
C. 3 and 4
D. 1 and 4

Answer: B

Model solution: Row 1 is wrong because Chandraketugarh is in West Bengal, not Odisha. Row 2 is correct: Inamgaon in Maharashtra is a major Chalcolithic site. Row 3 is correct: Mangadu in Kerala is associated with megalithic evidence. Row 4 is wrong: Salihundam is a Buddhist site known for stupas and monastic remains, not a rock-cut cave-shrine complex. Official key: B.

Examiner-grade requirement: UPSC swaps one coordinate - state, period or site type. Verify each row independently.

PYQ 6. 2025 Prelims Q19 - Ashokan Officers

Status: Official Set-A question and official Set-A key verified locally.

Question: Ashokan inscriptions suggest that Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta were important officers at which level?

Option
A. Village-level administration
B. District-level administration
C. Provincial administration

Option
D. Central administration

Answer: B

Model solution: The terms occur in Ashokan administrative communication and are associated with district-level functions. The question demonstrates how epigraphic vocabulary supplies administrative history. Official Set-A key: B.

Examiner-grade requirement: Do not memorize officers apart from the inscriptional context that establishes their role.

PYQ 7. 2026 Prelims Q3 - Pali Texts and Coin Archaeology

Status: Official Set-A question verified directly from the scan; official locally held key is provisional. The local routing ledger misnumbers this printed item as Q6; the paper itself controls.

Question: Pali texts contain early definite references to coin terms, and this literary evidence is corroborated by punch-marked coins. Are these associated with (1) emergence of urban life and (2) transition to a money economy?

Option
A. 1 only
B. 2 only
C. Both 1 and 2
D. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: C

Model solution: Both associations are valid. Textual money vocabulary and archaeological coin finds converge in the context of expanding towns, states and monetized exchange. The official provisional Series-A key for printed Q3 is C.

Examiner-grade requirement: This is a model triangulation question: literary terminology gains strength through material corroboration.

PYQ 8. 2026 Prelims Q7 - Place-Value Evidence in Inscriptions

Status: Official Set-A question verified; official locally held key is provisional.

Question: Statements: earliest epigraphic use of place value in India in Mankani plates (595-596 CE); general use in inscriptions in the 9th century; Sanskrit inscriptions in Southeast Asia by the 7th century.

Option
A. 1 and 2 only
B. 1 and 3 only
C. 2 and 3 only
D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: D

Model solution: The official provisional Series-A key treats all three statements as correct. Method lesson: epigraphy can date the adoption and geographical diffusion of a technical notation, but the conclusion must remain tied to the surviving corpus. Provisional key: D.

Examiner-grade requirement: Distinguish earliest surviving epigraphic use from invention, universal use or exclusive origin.

PYQ 9. 2026 Prelims Q8 - Inference from Harappan Archaeology

Status: Official Set-A question verified; official locally held key is provisional.

Question: Finds include household spindle-whorls without spinning wheels; graduated weights and scales; and large baked-brick houses around courtyards with private wells and bathing platforms. Which inferences follow?

Option
A. 1 and 2 only
B. 2 and 3 only
C. 1 and 3 only
D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A

Model solution: Inference 1 is reasonable: spindle-whorls in houses suggest labour-intensive household spinning. Inference 2 is reasonable: graduated weights/scales indicate developed measurement knowledge. Inference 3 is not supported: private wells and substantial houses do not establish a common-property system. The provisional Series-A key is A.

Examiner-grade requirement: Infer only what the material relation supports; do not smuggle a modern property category into the evidence.

Mains 1. Original 10-marker 1 - Why Context Matters

10 marks | 150 words

Question: Why is archaeological context as important as the artefact itself? Explain with Indian examples.

Model answer: An artefact becomes historical evidence through layer, findspot, association and formation process. **At Inamgaon**, high nitrogen in courtyard soils supports animal tethering, while sea-fish bones and molluscan shells found over 200 km inland indicate coastal contact; the assemblage proves activities and exchange, but not the identity or scale of traders. **The Jogalthembi hoard's 9,270 Nahapana silver coins counter-struck by Gautamiputra Satakarni** establishes relative political sequence and deliberate revalidation; as a selected buried hoard, it is not a neutral sample of all circulation. **Painted Grey Ware in stratified levels at epic-associated sites such as Hastinapura** demonstrates occupation and a material horizon, not the Mahabharata war or named characters. A stray coin or looted seal may retain image and metal yet lose depositional chronology, circulation and social meaning. Excavation is therefore controlled recovery of relationships, not treasure collection: the object supplies attributes, while context determines which historical claim those attributes can sustain.

Why this earns marks: It explains the principle through three named Indian cases, distinguishes proof from overreach in each, and closes with a direct context-versus-object verdict suited to 10 marks.

Top-answer checklist: Definition; layer/findspot/association; Inamgaon plus coin/Harappan example; looting; clear verdict.

Mains 2. Original 10-marker 2 - Inscriptions and Coins

10 marks | 150 words

Question: Compare the contribution of inscriptions and coins to the chronology of early historic India.

Model answer: Inscriptions usually provide explicit anchors; coins more often build relative sequence. **Ashoka's edicts refer to events from his eighth to twenty-seventh regnal years**, linking policy to a reign, although only surviving proclamations-not complete annual administration-are represented. **Rudradaman's Junagadh inscription, dated Shaka 72 (150-51 CE)** fixes a ruler and public work in an era, but its prashasti remains selective. Coins fill different gaps: legends, portraits, dies and hoards reconstruct rulers and order where texts are thin. **The Jogalthembi hoard of 9,270 Nahapana coins counter-struck by Gautamiputra Satakarni** makes Nahapana's issue earlier than the Satavahana overtype and supports political succession; hoard selection and prolonged circulation prevent an exact frontier map. Indo-Greek series similarly recover otherwise obscure rulers, but attribution can remain disputed.

Thus inscriptions are strongest for dated acts and genealogical claims, coins for issue sequence and circulation; chronology is firmest when an epigraphic date anchors a numismatic series in a secure archaeological layer.

Why this earns marks: It compares rather than lists, uses three precise chronological anchors, explains what each proves and cannot prove, and synthesizes their complementary value within 10 marks.

Top-answer checklist: Compare, do not list; explicit date versus relative sequence; one epigraphic and one numismatic case; synthesis.

Mains 3. Original 15-marker 1 - Norm and Social Reality

15 marks | 250 words

Question: Ancient literary sources stand between social norm and social reality. Discuss.

Model answer: Ancient texts are neither social censuses nor inventions; genre places them between description and projects to order society. **The Manusmriti and other Dharmashastra texts** prescribe varna, gender and household conduct. Repeated injunctions prove Brahmanical ideals and anxieties, not uniform compliance; **Naganika's Naneghat inscription** and other female or non-royal donations show forms of agency that prescriptive models do not exhaust, though epigraphy also over-represents donors.

The Rigveda and Brahmanas preserve kinship, ritual and economic vocabulary. Their layered ritual world cannot be mapped mechanically onto **Painted Grey Ware settlements at Hastinapura or Atranjikhhera**: archaeology establishes occupation and technology, not the identity of textual peoples. **The Pali Vinaya and Jatakas** describe monks, merchants, towns and money terms; punch-marked coins and Northern Black Polished Ware in early urban contexts corroborate monetization and urban life, but moral tales and canonical redaction limit direct reportage.

Regional literature shows the same tension. **Pattinappalai and Maduraikkanchi*** evoke ports, rulers, occupations and exchange in Tamilakam; Tamil-Brahmi potsherds and craft remains at **Arikamedu and Kodumanal** confirm literacy and maritime-commercial networks, while bardic convention and uncertain anthology dates prevent literal quantification. Epic and Puranic genealogies likewise preserve memory only after recension and inscriptional-numismatic checks.

The historian must therefore ask layer, genre, author, audience and corroboration. Literature reveals both lived possibilities and attempts to shape them; its highest value lies in analysing the gap between norm, memory and practice.

Why this earns marks: It discusses five linked evidence clusters across Brahmanical, Buddhist and Tamil traditions, repeatedly states what corroboration proves and limits, and reaches a nuanced 15-mark judgement.

Top-answer checklist: Genre diversity; norm-practice distinction; Brahmanical plus heterodox/Sangam examples; corroboration; nuanced conclusion.

Mains 4. Original 15-marker 2 - Archaeology and Anonymous History

15 marks | 250 words

Question: Archaeology often provides an anonymous history, yet it can be more inclusive than texts. Examine.

Model answer: Archaeology is “anonymous” because houses, pots, seeds, bones and refuse rarely name their makers; it tracks long social processes better than individual events. That limitation can widen history beyond literate elites. **At Inamgaon**, courtyard nitrogen, faunal remains and marine shells reconstruct animal keeping and inland-coastal contact; they recover routine activity, although the actors and exchange mechanism remain unnamed. **Kodumanal's spindle whorls, beads, workshop debris and Tamil-Brahmi potsherds** reveal craft production, literacy and trade beyond court narratives; excavation coverage and inscribed ownership remain partial.

Urban archaeology also recovers collective practice. **Mohenjo-daro's wells, bathing platforms and drains**, read with standardized Harappan weights, show household water management and regulated exchange, but cannot identify political institutions while the script remains unread. **Sanchi and Bharhut's monuments plus short donor inscriptions** bring lay donors, women, artisans and guild-linked patronage into view; survival still favours durable religious giving. Bioarchaeology adds embodied history: the **2026 multidisciplinary study of eight Rakhigarhi burials** can test diet, mobility, disease and biological affinity, but a burial sample cannot represent the entire Harappan population or reveal language and caste.

Archaeology is therefore not automatically democratic. Preservation, survey priorities, cemetery selection and elite-monument bias create silences, while modern labels can over-socialize material cultures. Systematic regional survey, household excavation, flotation, osteology and prompt publication improve inclusion. Archaeology may not always name ordinary people, but it reconstructs the material routines and inequalities in which they lived.

Why this earns marks: It examines both anonymity and inclusion through five named cases, qualifies each inference, and balances archaeology's social reach against preservation and sampling limits for 15 marks.

Top-answer checklist: Explain anonymous; everyday-life examples; inclusiveness and its limits; methods that improve representation; verdict.

Mains 5. Original 20-marker 1 - Multi-Source Reconstruction

20 marks | 300-350 words

Question: Ancient Indian history is a multi-source reconstruction rather than a narrative contained in any one archive. Critically examine.

Model answer: As R.S. Sharma's changing source profile and Upinder Singh's potential-limit method suggest, no archive covers the whole ancient past. Multi-source reconstruction is necessary because each class reveals a different scale and carries a different silence.

Harappan history rests on cities such as **Mohenjo-daro and Dholavira**, seals, weights, craft debris and burials; these prove urban planning and standardized practices, but the undeciphered script blocks an indigenous narrative and cautions against naming the polity. **Vedic and epic texts** preserve ritual, kinship and memory, while **Painted Grey Ware at Hastinapura and Atranjikhhera** establishes settlement and material sequence; overlap does not prove an "Aryan" ethnicity or the Mahabharata war.

For the second urbanization, **Pali texts' money and merchant vocabulary**, punch-marked coins and Northern Black Polished Ware at early towns jointly support monetization and urban growth; canonical layering and uneven coin use prevent an all-India model. Mauryan reconstruction is firmer because **Ashokan edicts**, the **Kumrahar-Pataliputra archaeological complex** and **Megasthenes' surviving fragments** converge on kingship, communication and an imperial centre. Yet edicts express policy, palace remains do not reveal the whole state, and Megasthenes reaches us through later quotation.

Regional sequences show the same method. **Nashik-Karle inscriptions** and the **Jogalthembi overstrikes of Nahapana coins by Gautamiputra Satakarni** establish patronage and relative political succession, but donative rhetoric and a selected hoard cannot map exact frontiers. **Pattinappalai and Maduraikkanchi*** gain historical weight from Tamil-Brahmi and craft evidence at **Arikamedu and Kodumanal** and Mediterranean wares; together they prove maritime connectivity, not total trade volume. For the Guptas, the **Prayaga prashasti**, Samudragupta's martial and lyrical coin types, and visual remains reconstruct imperial ideology, while their royal splendour cannot stand for general prosperity.

Critical reconstruction therefore authenticates, dates and contextualizes evidence, matches scale, tests independence and preserves contradiction. It is not a vote among sources but question-specific weighting: convergence narrows possibilities, while explicit limits keep inference historical rather than mythic.

Why this earns marks: It critically integrates seven period-specific evidence clusters, explains the distinct proof and limitation of each, invokes historians methodologically, and ends with a reasoned 20-mark verdict.

Top-answer checklist: Period-varying evidence profile; source-wise value/limit; three triangulation cases; contradictions; methodological verdict.

Mains 6. Original 20-marker 2 - Science and Interpretation

20 marks | 300-350 words

Question: Scientific techniques have transformed ancient-history research, but they have not eliminated interpretation. Analyse.

Model answer: Scientific archaeology has transformed ancient history by converting materials into testable chronological, biological and environmental evidence, but every measurement still depends on context and a historical question.

Radiocarbon dating, pioneered by Willard Libby, gives probability ranges for organic samples and has refined settlement chronologies; contamination, “old wood,” calibration and insecure association mean it dates the sample's death, not automatically an event. **Thermoluminescence dates from Didwana-about 150,000 and 144,000 BP for Middle Palaeolithic contexts**-show how heated minerals can extend chronology beyond texts, but laboratory assumptions and depositional integrity still govern the claim.

Science also reconstructs behaviour. **At Inamgaon**, high courtyard nitrogen supports animal tethering, while marine fish bones and shells over 200 km inland indicate coastal contact; post-depositional chemistry and the unknown exchange mechanism limit interpretation. Archaeobotanical flotation recovers seeds and grains that ordinary excavation misses, and faunal age profiles can suggest diet or herd management; preservation and sampling decide whose foodways survive. **X-ray fluorescence of coins** can identify elemental composition non-destructively and test minting or debasement hypotheses; similar alloys do not by themselves identify a mint or economic crisis.

Landscape and bodies widen the archive. Remote sensing and GIS identify palaeochannels, roads, moats and buried structures, but anomalies need ground verification and dating. In June 2026, skeletal material from **eight Rakhigarhi burials, including three complete skeletons, was transferred to AnSI** for aDNA, isotope, osteological, palaeopathological and environmental study. These methods can test biological affinity, mobility, diet and disease; a small burial sample cannot directly reveal Harappan language, caste or political identity.

As Upinder Singh's archaeometry framework emphasizes, measurement becomes history only after context, comparison and source criticism. Science is therefore most transformative when integrated with stratigraphy, artefact association, inscriptions and texts. It narrows possibilities and quantifies uncertainty; it does not replace the interpretive judgement that connects a result to society.

Why this earns marks: It analyses seven scientific evidence routes with named Indian cases, explains the inference and methodological limit of each, and sustains the transformation-without-determinism thesis required for 20 marks.

Top-answer checklist: Range of methods; India/current example; sample/calibration/baseline limits; identity warning; integrated verdict.

Practice Audit: What Is Worth Writing - [CORE MAINS]

The verified PYQs remain the priority. The original 10/15/20-mark models immediately above are retained because they train distinct answer tasks: context, inscriptions/coins, norm versus practice, archaeology, multi-source reconstruction and science. The six repeated rehearsal models were removed because they repeated these same answer spines without adding a new PYQ route.

Verified-PYQ ownership and frequency

PYQ route	Audit judgement	What to retain
2018 GS-I: Chinese and Arab travellers	Directly relevant Mains ownership ; this is the clearest verified source-method demand.	traveller as situated observation + cross-check + limitation
2020 GS-I: rock-cut architecture	Indirect source-method support through visual/material evidence.	form/technology + patronage/use + limitation
2023-2026 Prelims source/site/text questions	Directly relevant Prelims ownership , but annual frequency is limited and cannot be treated as a guarantee.	statement precision, source matching and elimination logic
Original 10/15/20 markers	Core practice , not official PYQs.	claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Answer-worthiness filter

Keep an example only if it performs one of three jobs: identifies a source class accurately, supplies evidence for an argument, or supplies a limitation/cross-check. Compress a long list of sites, travellers, methods or scholars when it performs none of these jobs. A competent GS-I answer needs a few explained examples, not exhaustive catalogues.